

Oscar Wilde

His Life

Oscar Wilde was born in **Dublin in 1854**. He studied at **Trinity College Dublin** and then at the **University of Oxford**, where he graduated in Classics and became known for his unusual personality. At Oxford, he was influenced by the philosopher **Walter Pater**, who believed that life should be lived like a work of art, full of beauty and vivid experiences. Wilde took these ideas further by presenting himself as a **dandy** — a person who dresses very elegantly, loves luxury, and cares deeply about beauty and style. His dandy lifestyle was often financed through inherited wealth.

After moving to **London**, Wilde became famous for his charm and wit. He rejected ordinary middle-class values and embraced a life of elegance and artistic refinement.

In **1881**, Wilde traveled to the **United States** on a lecture tour, where he spoke about **Aestheticism** — the idea that art exists for its own sake, not to teach moral lessons ("Art for Art's Sake"). He became well known as both a writer and a public speaker.

Back in Europe, he married **Constance Lloyd** and had **two sons**. In **1891**, he published his only novel, ***The Picture of Dorian Gray***, which explored the dangers of vanity and moral corruption.

Wilde then turned to writing plays, which were very successful:

- ***Lady Windermere's Fan***
- ***An Ideal Husband***
- ***The Importance of Being Earnest*** — his most famous comedy
- ***Salomé*** — a dark tragedy that caused great scandal

His life changed dramatically because of his **relationship with Lord Alfred Douglas**. This led to a **public trial** and Wilde was sent to **prison for two years**. While in prison, he wrote ***De Profundis***, a long and personal letter reflecting on his life and suffering.

After leaving prison, Wilde moved to **France**, living in poverty under a false name. He wrote one final work, ***The Ballad of Reading Gaol***, inspired by his time in prison. He **died in Paris in 1900**.

The Picture of Dorian Gray

Plot

The Picture of Dorian Gray (1891) is set in **London** and tells the story of **Dorian Gray**, a young man whose beauty fascinates the artist **Basil Hallward**, who paints his portrait. Influenced by the cynical **Lord Henry Wotton**, Dorian becomes obsessed with pleasure and excess. He wishes to stay young forever while the portrait ages in his place — and his wish is mysteriously granted.

Over time, Dorian's selfishness and cruelty grow, and he ruins the lives of many people around him. He even **murders Basil** when Basil confronts him about the corrupted portrait. In the end, Dorian tries to destroy the painting in a desperate act, but by stabbing it he **kills himself**. His body becomes old and ugly, while the portrait returns to its original beauty — showing the full consequences of his immoral life.

Characters and Themes

Dorian Gray represents youth, beauty, and innocence — but he gradually becomes corrupted by vanity and the desire for pleasure. **Lord Henry Wotton** stands for the immoral philosophy of Aestheticism: he pushes Dorian to pursue pleasure above everything else. **Basil Hallward**, the painter, represents morality and conscience — he is the opposite of Lord Henry.

The portrait symbolizes **Dorian's corrupted soul** and shows the contrast between outer appearance and inner reality. The main themes of the novel are:

- The obsession with **beauty and eternal youth** (the "Faustian" desire — like a deal with the devil)
- The **double nature of man**: how people look on the outside vs. who they really are
- A **critique of Victorian society** and its hypocrisy
- Wilde's moral message: **every excess has consequences, and no one can escape reality**

Style

Wilde wrote the novel in the **third person**, using witty dialogue, paradoxes, and elegant language. His style is very similar to drama: characters are often defined more by **what they say and how they speak** than by descriptions from the narrator.